STERLITE TECHNOLOGIES

VISIT NOTE

COFFEE WITH CEO

KEY DATA

Rating	BUY
Sector relative	Outperformer
Price (INR)	201
12 month price target (INR)	280
52 Week High/Low	206/53
Market cap (INR bn/USD bn)	98/1.1
Free float (%)	53.2
Avg. daily value traded (INR mn)	1,206.0

SHAREHOLDING PATTERN

	Dec-25	Sep-25	Jun-25
Promoter	44.45%	44.46%	44.41%
FII	10.93%	11.28%	6.74%
DII	11.04%	10.79%	11.33%
Pledge	0.00%	0.00%	0.00%

FINANCIALS

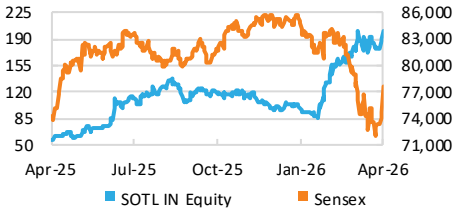
(INR mn)

Year to March	FY25A	FY26E	FY27E	FY28E
Revenue	39,960	46,688	63,267	73,796
EBITDA	4,160	5,616	10,307	13,585
Adjusted profit	(720)	582	4,074	6,604
Diluted EPS (INR)	(1.5)	1.2	8.4	13.6
EPS growth (%)	(14.5)	nm	600.2	62.1
RoAE (%)	(6.1)	2.1	18.2	23.8
P/E (x)	nm	166.3	23.8	14.7
EV/EBITDA (x)	26.5	19.6	10.5	7.7
Dividend yield (%)	0	0	0	0

CHANGE IN ESTIMATES

	Revised estimates		% Revision	
Year to March	FY27E	FY28E	FY27E	FY28E
Revenue	63,267	73,796	0.2%	0.3%
EBITDA	10,307	13,585	4.8%	10.0%
Adjusted profit	4,074	6,604	9.5%	16.3%
Diluted EPS (INR)	8.4	13.6	9.5%	16.3%

PRICE PERFORMANCE



Global data centre supply chain beneficiary

We recently met with MD Mr Ankit Agarwal of Sterlite Technologies to fathom business dynamics amid a pickup in demand from telecom operators, hyperscalers and drone warfare application. Takeaways: i) demand to sustain, underpinned by data centre (DC) opportunities; ii) supply chain to stay constrained by limited raw material availability; and iii) stepping up of R&D investment to bolster product capabilities.

Spot prices of optical fibre have risen materially in the past three months due to demand-supply mismatch. We upgrade FY27E/28E EPS by ~10%/16%, factoring in better margin led by improved realisations. We now value STL at 11x (earlier 8x) Mar-28E EBITDA, implying a TP of INR280 (earlier INR200). At CMP, STL trades at ~8.2x FY28E EV/EBITDA.

More insights from meeting

- Strong global fibre demand being reported driven by investments in 5G and network upgrades, FTTH rollout along with increasing fibre count, hyperscaler/AI investments in fibre dense data centres and rising fibre usage in drone warfare.
- Historically, Sterlite Technologies (STL) focused on Tier I/Tier II telecom demand. The company is now well positioned to capture emerging data centre opportunities supported by expanding data centre product capabilities. The next few quarters are likely to be pivotal for the DC order book.
- STL's local manufacturing facility in the US helps mitigate tariff-related and macro risks, providing a competitive edge over peers.
- Demand for high-end fibre is increasing while the number of players with such capabilities remains limited, contributing to a sharp increase in prices.
- Data centres are upgrading data transfer speeds from 300–400Gbps to 800Gbps, necessitating a shift from copper-based connectivity to fibre-based connectivity.
- Fibre accounts for ~1% of overall data centre capex while interconnect solutions account for ~2%; as per industry estimates, data centres should contribute 30% of overall optical fibre demand globally ex-China by 2027.
- Industry-wide capacity additions have remained slow, reflecting a conservative approach following prior cycles where several facilities were shut down.
- STL's product innovation pipeline remains intact with the company increasing R&D investments to keep pace with rising demand complexity.
- While demand remains elevated, supply chain constraints, particularly the availability of raw materials such as Germanium, Helium and polymers, remain a key growth bottleneck.

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Financial Statements

Income Statement (INR mn)

Year to March	FY25A	FY26E	FY27E	FY28E
Total operating income	39,960	46,688	63,267	73,796
Gross profit	19,950	23,438	32,423	37,559
Employee costs	6,100	6,712	8,690	10,140
Other expenses	9,690	11,110	13,426	13,834
EBITDA	4,160	5,616	10,307	13,585
Depreciation	3,160	3,110	3,160	3,177
Less: Interest expense	2,410	2,170	2,195	2,082
Add: Other income	360	410	480	480
Profit before tax	(1,560)	596	5,432	8,805
Prov for tax	(330)	164	1,358	2,201
Less: Other adjustment	0	0	0	0
Reported profit	(1,230)	432	4,074	6,604
Less: Excp.item (net)	510	150	0	0
Adjusted profit	(720)	582	4,074	6,604
Diluted shares o/s	486	484	484	484
Adjusted diluted EPS	(1)	1	8	14
DPS (INR)	0	0	0	0
Tax rate (%)	21.2	27.5	25.0	25.0

Balance Sheet (INR mn)

Year to March	FY25A	FY26E	FY27E	FY28E
Share capital	980	968	968	968
Reserves	18,920	19,352	23,426	30,030
Shareholders funds	19,900	20,320	24,394	30,998
Minority interest	0	0	0	0
Borrowings	18,180	18,743	19,424	20,233
Trade payables	10,280	11,057	13,525	16,278
Other liabs & prov	5,680	6,279	6,994	7,849
Total liabilities	55,270	57,752	65,830	77,007
Net block	26,710	26,289	25,910	26,469
Intangible assets	2,570	2,249	1,968	1,732
Capital WIP	230	800	800	800
Total fixed assets	29,510	29,338	28,678	29,001
Non current inv	900	900	900	900
Cash/cash equivalent	4,680	5,614	7,466	12,317
Sundry debtors	8,260	8,902	13,556	16,898
Loans & advances	0	0	0	0
Other assets	11,590	12,667	14,900	17,561
Total assets	55,270	57,752	65,830	77,007

Important Ratios (%)

Year to March	FY25A	FY26E	FY27E	FY28E
Direct cost as % of rev	50.1	49.8	48.8	49.1
Staff cost as % of rev	15.3	14.4	13.7	13.7
Other exp as % of rev	24.2	23.8	21.2	18.7
EBITDA margin (%)	10.4	12.0	16.3	18.4
Net profit margin (%)	(1.8)	1.2	6.4	8.9
Rev Growth (% YoY)	(2.1)	16.8	35.5	16.6
EBITDA growth (% YoY)	(12.2)	35.0	83.5	31.8
Adj. profit growth (%)	1.4	nm	600.2	62.1

Free Cash Flow (INR mn)

Year to March	FY25A	FY26E	FY27E	FY28E
Reported profit	(1,230)	432	4,074	6,604
Add: Depreciation	3,160	3,110	3,160	3,177
Interest (net of tax)	1,900	1,573	1,646	1,562
Others	900	597	549	521
Less: Changes in WC	(1,260)	(220)	(3,564)	(2,239)
Operating cash flow	3,470	5,492	5,865	9,624
Less: Capex	(1,220)	(2,938)	(2,500)	(3,500)
Free cash flow	2,250	2,554	3,365	6,124

Assumptions (%)

Year to March	FY25A	FY26E	FY27E	FY28E
GDP (YoY %)	6.0	6.2	6.2	6.2
Repo rate (%)	6.0	5.0	5.0	5.0
USD/INR (average)	84.0	82.0	82.0	82.0
Tax rate	21.2	27.5	25.0	25.0
Capex (INR mn)	1,220.0	2,937.8	2,500.0	3,500.0
Inventory days	142.1	122.9	110.5	117.0
Receivable days	110.7	67.1	64.8	75.3
Payable days	163.4	94.8	84.7	90.3
Cash conversion cycle days	89.4	95.2	90.5	102.0

Key Ratios

Year to March	FY25A	FY26E	FY27E	FY28E
RoE (%)	(6.1)	2.1	18.2	23.8
RoCE (%)	3.0	7.6	18.4	22.9
Inventory days	142	123	110	117
Receivable days	111	67	65	75
Payable days	292	167	145	150
Working cap (% sales)	8.2	7.7	11.6	13.1
Gross debt/equity (x)	0.9	0.9	0.8	0.7
Net debt/equity (x)	0.7	0.6	0.5	0.3
Interest coverage (x)	0.4	1.2	3.3	5.0

Valuation Metrics

Year to March	FY25A	FY26E	FY27E	FY28E
Diluted P/E (x)	nm	166.3	23.8	14.7
Price/BV (x)	4.9	4.8	4.0	3.1
EV/EBITDA (x)	26.5	19.6	10.5	7.7
Dividend yield (%)	0	0	0	0

Valuation Drivers

Year to March	FY25A	FY26E	FY27E	FY28E
EPS growth (%)	(14.5)	nm	600.2	62.1
RoE (%)	(6.1)	2.1	18.2	23.8
EBITDA growth (%)	(12.2)	35.0	83.5	31.8
Payout ratio (%)	nm	0	0	0

Source: Company and Nuvama estimates

Bio in brief

Mr Ankit Agarwal

MD of Sterlite Technologies

Mr Ankit Agarwal has been leading the growth journey of Sterlite Technologies (STL) as it transforms billions of lives by connecting the world. Over the past 14 years for which he has been at STL, Ankit has been a change agent within the company and a driving force towards connecting the unconnected across the globe. He is the force behind STL's dramatic global expansion, customer-first ethos, R&D focus and strategic joint ventures & acquisitions. He has strengthened STL's presence in India, the US, UK, Italy, China and Brazil. He holds sustainability very close to his heart and is leading the company's ambitious Net-Zero by 2030 target, from the front. He is extremely passionate about improvement in health, education and the environment through digital inclusion in India. Recognised as a 40 under 40 leader, Ankit is a strong supporter of young and entrepreneurial talent. He is a fitness enthusiast, an athlete, a long-distance runner and encourages his teams and young people to work towards solid all-round growth at work and in life. Prior to STL, Ankit was building Vedanta's corporate portfolio while overseeing multiple M&As, including the USD8.6bn acquisition of Cairn India. Ankit has a Bachelor's degree from the University of Southern California and is an MBA from London Business School.

Industry overview

Historically, the optical fibre segment largely catered to telecom demand driven by 3G-to-4G and 4G-to-5G network upgradation cycles. However, the current demand-supply mismatch is structural in nature, underpinned by a confluence of multiple demand drivers:

i. Telecom operators globally are accelerating fibre deployments to support 5G rollouts through fiberisation of towers.

ii. FTTH is increasingly becoming a core strategic priority for telcos as part of their subscriber acquisition and retention strategy.

iii. Countries are upgrading to a minimum broadband speed of 1Gbps with low latency, further driving fibre adoption.

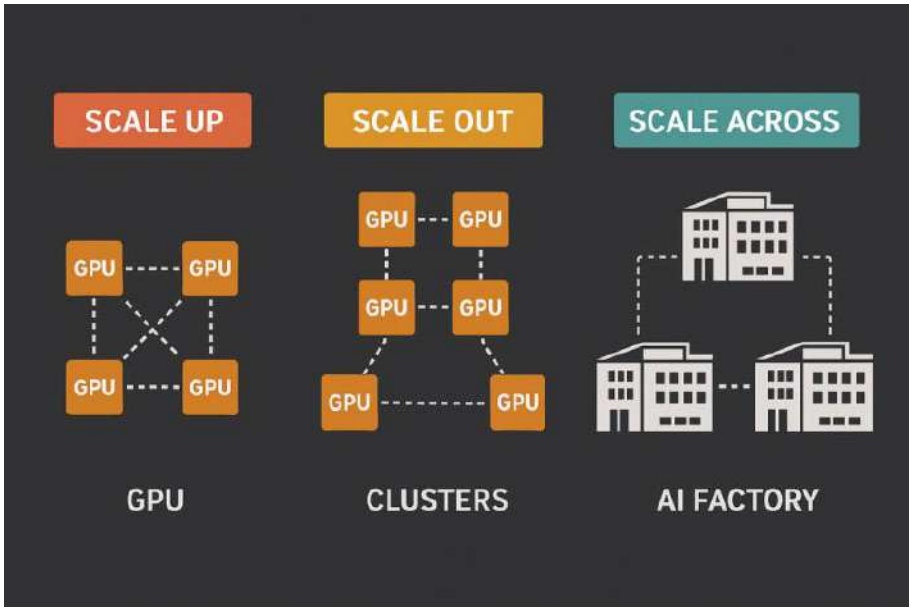
iv. Rapid data centre buildouts—driven by AI and cloud adoption—are generating significant incremental demand for optical fibre connectivity.

v. Governments are increasingly procuring fibre for drone warfare and surveillance infrastructure, emerging as a new and incremental demand source.

Hyperscaler capex continues to scale up rapidly, driving meaningful incremental demand for optical fibre across three distinct dimensions.

- **Scale up:** GPUs within a single data centre hub are densely interconnected, requiring significantly higher fibre density per hub and driving increased fibre consumption at the unit level.
- **Scale out:** Number of hubs at a given data centre site is expanding from three–four hubs earlier to eight hubs currently with each hub interconnected with the others. This densification has resulted in a ~10x increase in fibre demand.
- **Scale across:** Data centres spread across geographies need to be interconnected, a function traditionally performed by telecom operators. This segment—which historically accounted for ~5% of fibre demand—has now grown to 15–20%, providing an additional tailwind to overall demand momentum.

Exhibit 1: Key AI network trends fuelling infrastructure shift



Source: Medium.com

As the industry theme increasingly shifts towards data centres, fibre manufacturers with backward integration are best placed to capture this demand upcycle. Their ability to control raw material supply and maintain product quality at scale positions them as the primary beneficiaries of this structural shift.

Data centres are transitioning from 300–400Gbps to 800Gbps data transfer speeds, necessitating a shift from copper to fibre-based connectivity. This technology upgrade is a key incremental demand driver for optical fibre, as copper cables are unable to support the higher speeds and lower latency requirements of next-generation data centre infrastructure. The industry is currently at an inflection point of this 400Gbps-to-800Gbps transition, implying that the demand tailwind from this upgrade cycle is still in its early stages and is likely to accelerate meaningfully over the coming years.

Company updates

STL is well positioned to capitalise on rising demand, backed by a strong core product portfolio, recently launched data centre offerings and a robust pipeline of AI-focused products currently under development.

On the competitive landscape, STL's existing products are safeguarded by numerous IPs, making it difficult for competitors to replicate its offerings. Furthermore, industry-wide capacity addition has remained deliberately slow, reflective of a historically conservative approach. Several global facilities, particularly in China, were shut down in prior cycles as an oversupply of cable products drove prices well below cost, rendering operations unviable.

Restarting these facilities is neither quick nor inexpensive. It entails significant capital outlay as well as time and is unlikely to be triggered until there is clear visibility on the order book. This structural supply-side inertia combined with STL's differentiated product capabilities and IP moat, position the company favourably to capture market share in the ongoing demand upcycle.

Optical fibre prices have increased materially over the last three months, driven by a confluence of demand and supply-side factors as per Yingfeng Communication. On the demand side, elevated procurement for drone warfare applications, accelerating data centre buildouts and a revival in Tier-I US telecom demand post inventory destocking have collectively pushed demand well ahead of available supply. Simultaneously, rising demand for high-end speciality fibre—with very few players continuing to manufacture standard fibre—has further contributed to the price upcycle. On the supply side, structural constraints including industry-wide conservatism on glass capacity addition, LNG-related disruptions and the ongoing non-availability of raw materials such as Helium and Germanium have limited the ability of manufacturers to meaningfully ramp up output.

While the sustainability of current price levels remains uncertain, management is confident that prices are unlikely to revert to below-cost levels reported in prior cycles. STL's local manufacturing facility in the US provides an additional buffer, helping offset uncertainties arising from tariff and macro related headwinds and reinforcing the company's competitive positioning in its key growth market.

Traditionally, hyperscalers were constrained to build data centres within a limited geographic radius to minimise latency in data transfer. However, the advent of hollow core fibre is set to meaningfully alter this dynamic. Hollow core fibre reduces latency by ~38%, enabling hyperscalers to increase distance between data centre sites up to 20–30km beyond the earlier proximity constraints. This technological

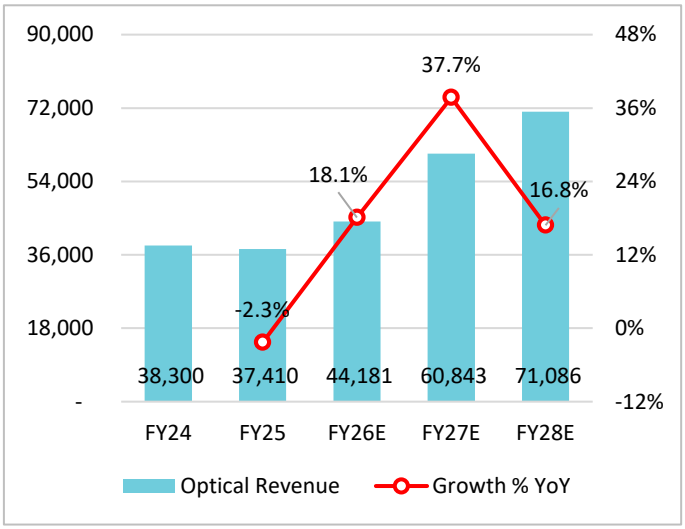
advancement significantly expands deployment flexibility and is likely to drive incremental fibre demand as hyperscalers reconfigure their infrastructure footprint.

The company is actively working towards diversifying its supply chain to mitigate these risks and ensure scalability beyond current scale.

Management would watch out for a couple of quarters before revising the earlier guidance of increasing revenue contribution from data centre and enterprise portfolio to 30% over the next 12–18 months from ~20% in Q3FY26. The near-term focus remains on improving utilisation levels before committing to any additional capacity expansion.

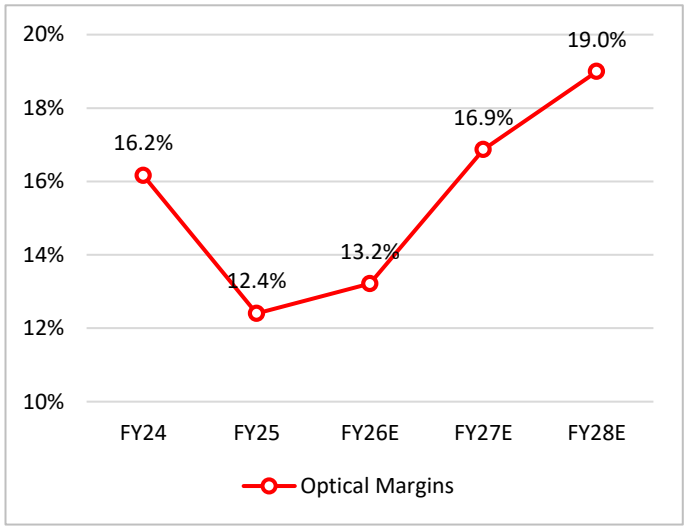
Finally, management reaffirmed their commitment to increasing R&D investments, aimed at strengthening STL's product innovation pipeline and maintaining its competitive edge in an increasingly complex demand environment.

Exhibit 2: Optical business revenue and growth



Source: Company, Nuvama Research

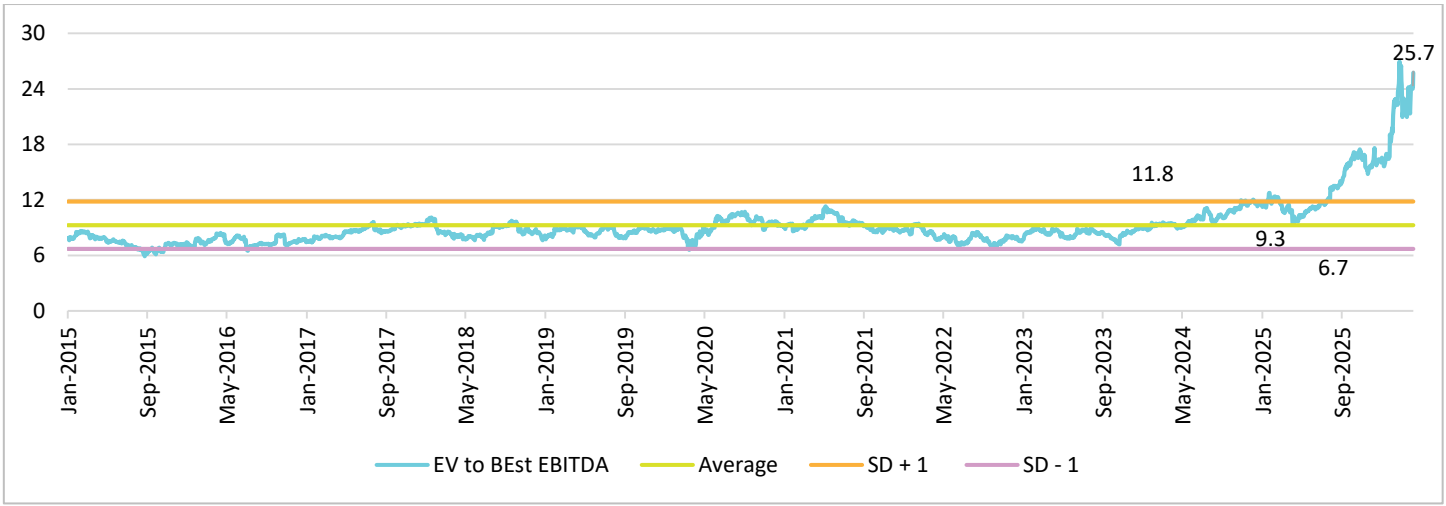
Exhibit 3: Optical business margin profile



Source: Company, Nuvama Research

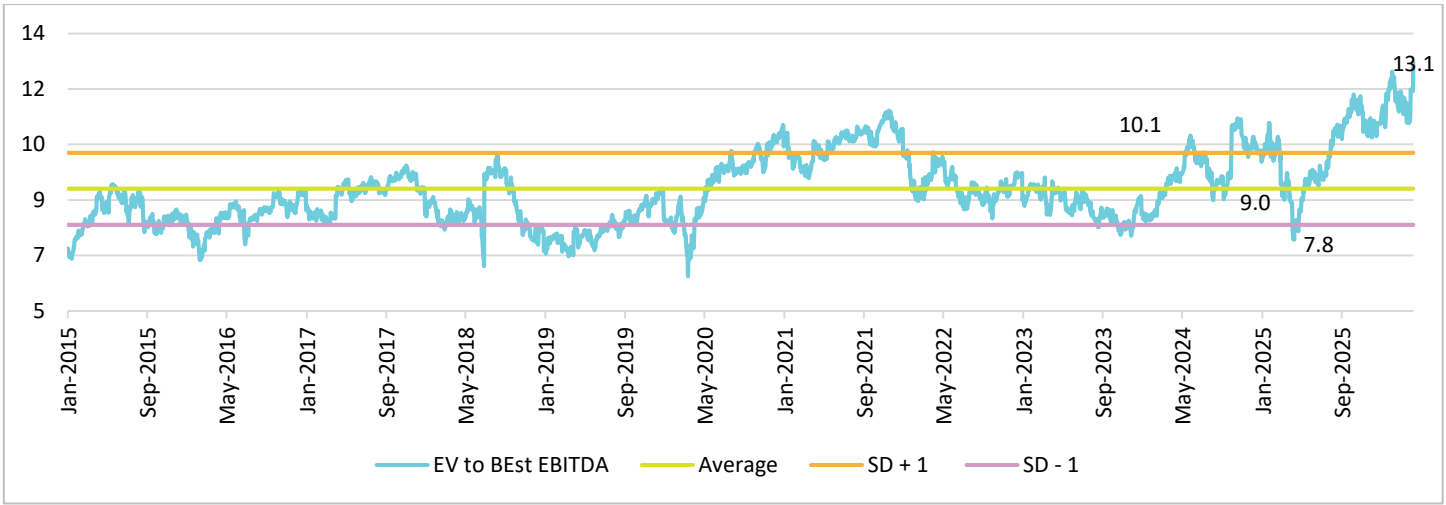
Valuation charts

Exhibit 4: Corning one-year-forward EV/EBITDA



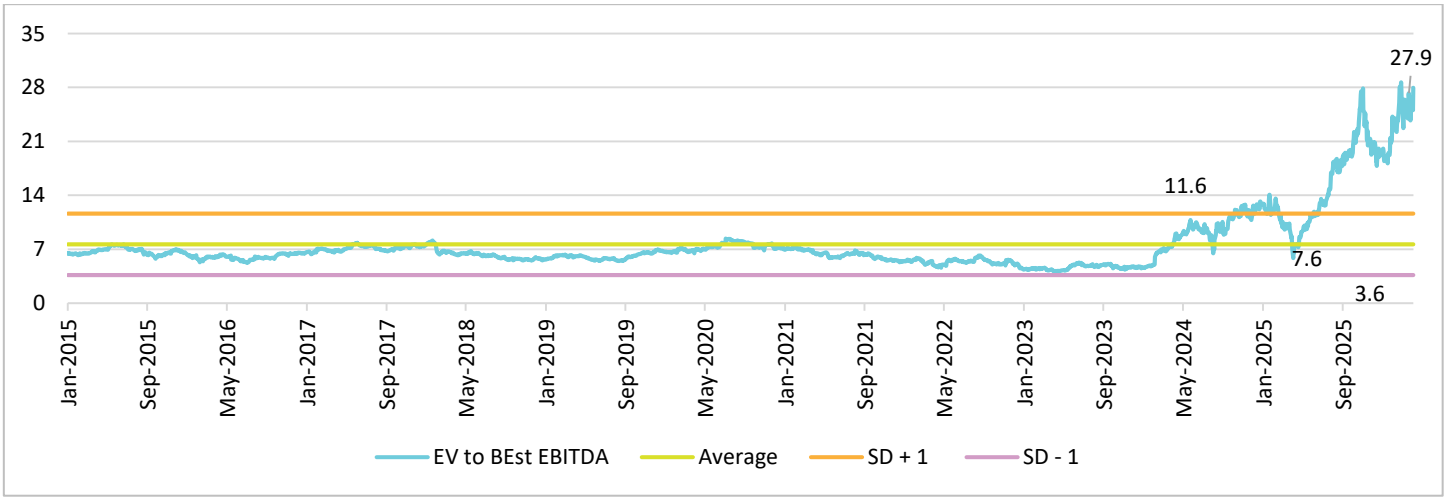
Source: Nuvama Research, Bloomberg

Exhibit 5: Prysmian one-year-forward EV/EBITDA



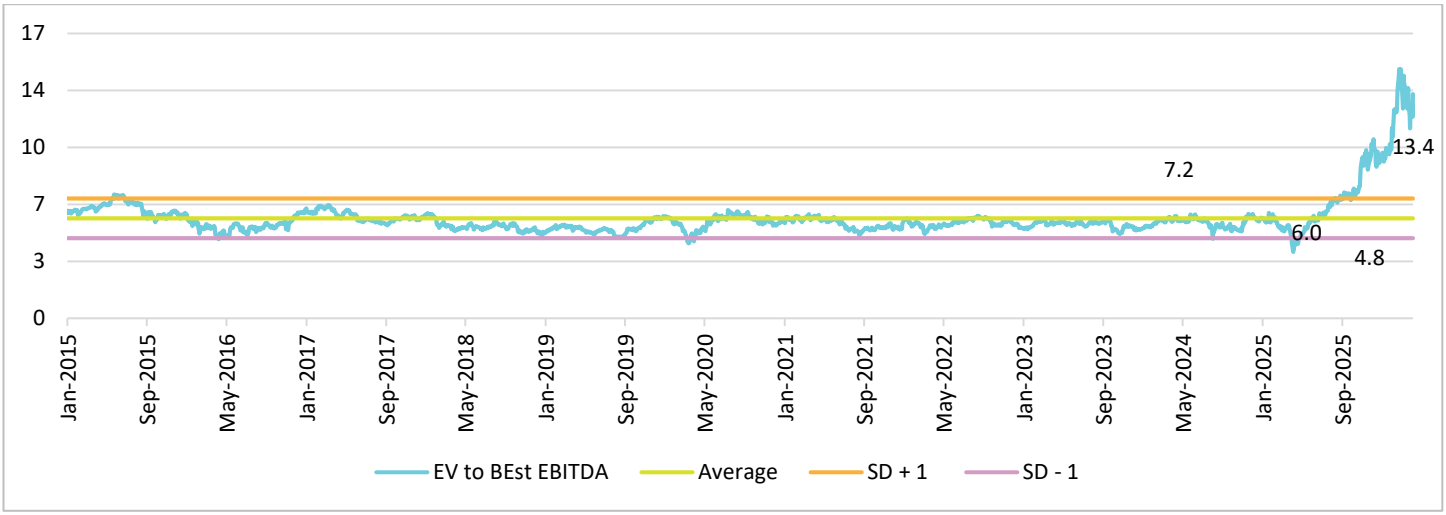
Source: Nuvama Research, Bloomberg

Exhibit 6: Fujikura one-year-forward EV/EBITDA



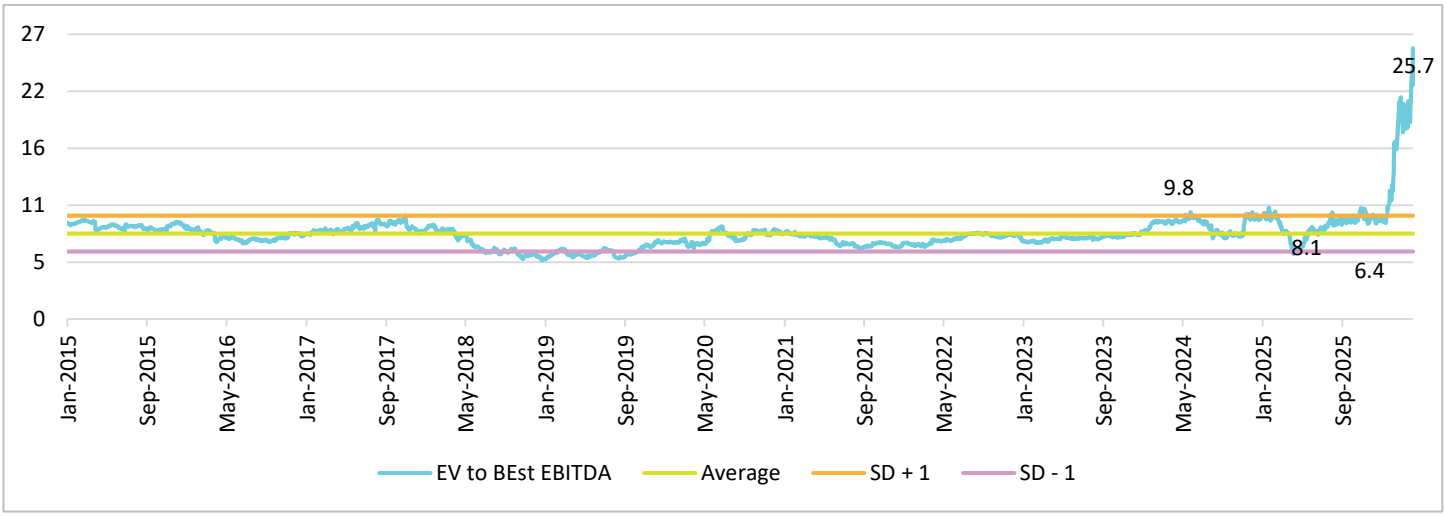
Source: Nuvama Research, Bloomberg

Exhibit 7: Sumitomo Electrical one-year-forward EV/EBITDA



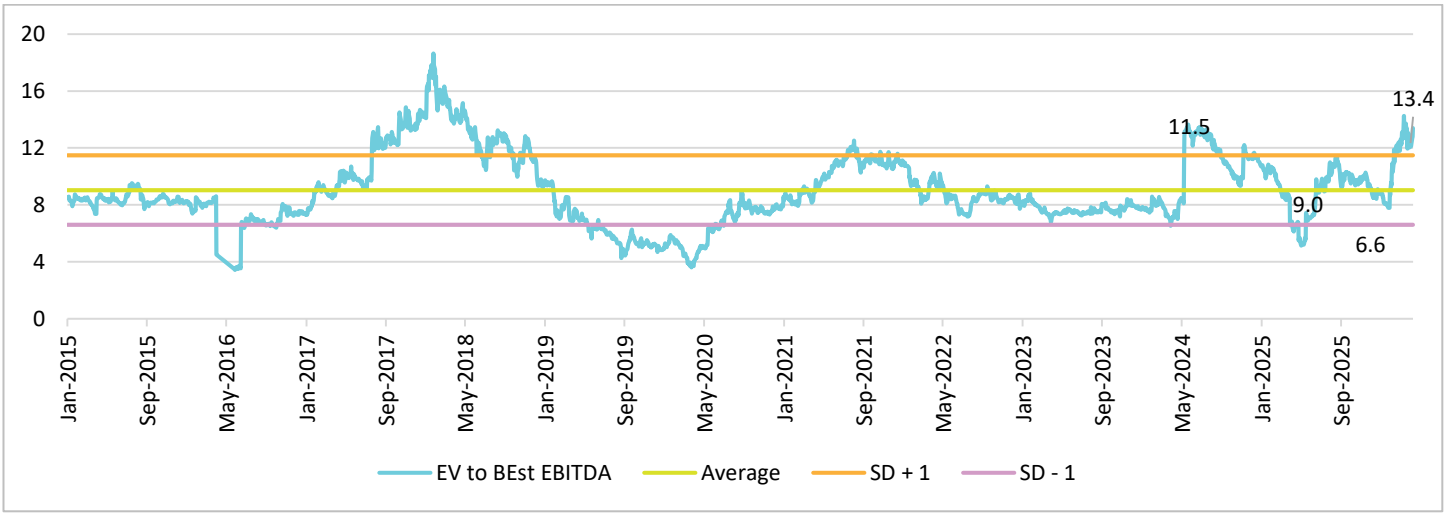
Source: Nuvama Research, Bloomberg

Exhibit 8: Furukawa one-year-forward EV/EBITDA



Source: Nuvama Research, Bloomberg

Exhibit 9: Sterlite Technologies one-year-forward EV/EBITDA



Source: Nuvama Research, Bloomberg

Company Description

Sterlite is India's largest and only fully integrated optical fibre cable manufacturer with OF and OFC capacity of 50mn and 42mn FKM respectively. It has manufacturing plants in Aurangabad, Silvassa, China, Brazil (through JV) and Italy. Company's offerings include optical products, system and network integration services. In services business, Sterlite has developed several network projects, such as, secure network for the armed forces, rural broadband through BharatNet, Smart Cities, and high-speed Fiber-to-the-Home (FTTH).

Investment Theme

We believe that Sterlite will be the key beneficiary of strong demand for fiber optic cables, given increasing fiberisation of towers, 5G rollout across geographies, increasing FTTH opportunity and BharatNet project. Sterlite is expected to leverage its capacity expansion with a new manufacturing plant setup in US which will drive further growth and bring down logistics costs. A superior cost structure due to integrated operations will lead to EBITDA margin expansion and improve return ratios, despite planned capex. The company is strategically expanding its portfolio of services leveraging its knowhow of complex network and relationships from the fiber business.

Key Risks

Downturn in global economy

Alternate connectivity technology

Continuing raw material inflation with high gas prices

Higher logistics costs

Telecom capex dip

Additional Data

Management

CEO	Ankit Agarwal
CFO	Ajay Jhanjhari
Chairman	Anil Agarwal
Executive Director	Pravin Agarwal
Auditor	PWC LLP

Holdings – Top 10*

	% Holding		% Holding
Twin Star Inter	42.90	LIC	1.17
Bandhan Mutual	5.85	Vedanta Ltd	0.98
Teachers Insura	2.46	BalckRock Inc	0.92
HDFC AMC	2.41	Dimensional Fun	0.63
Vanguard Group	2.23	Motilal Oswal A	0.19

**Latest public data*

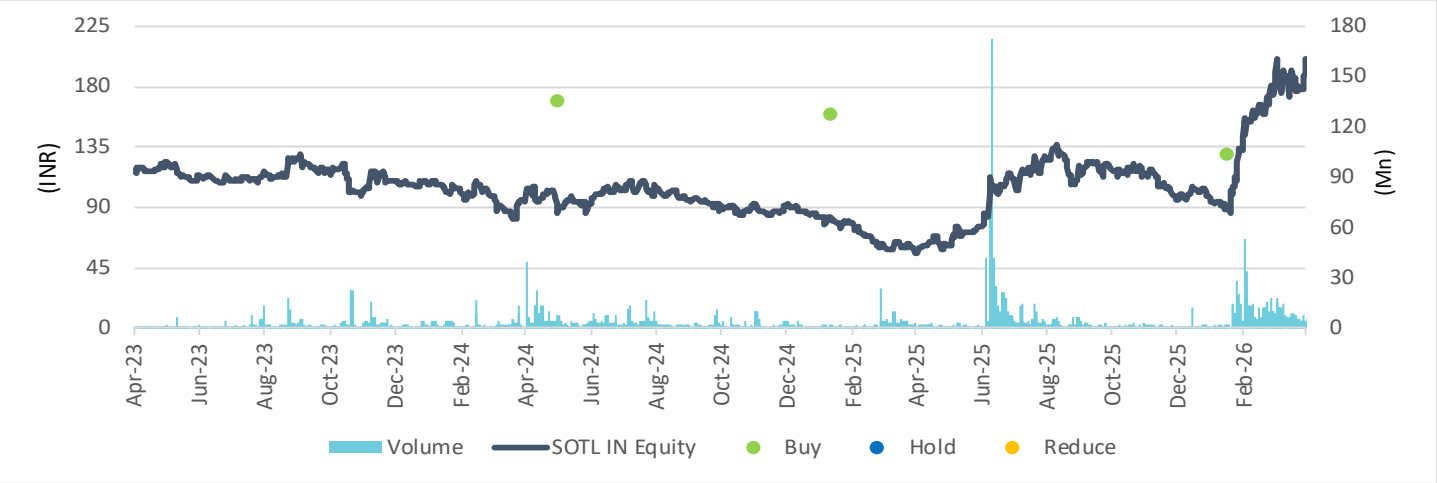
Recent Company Research

Date	Title	Price	Reco
07-Feb-26	Tariff-related uncertainties now behind; *Company Update*	132	Buy
23-Jan-26	Growth revival; margins under pressure; *Result Update*	93	Buy
06-Nov-25	Growth despite tariff headwinds; *Result Update*	113	Buy

Recent Sector Research

Date	Name of Co./Sector	Title
10-Feb-26	Route Mobile	Revenue growth remains under pressure; *Result Update*
06-Feb-26	Bharti Airtel	Stable quarter; momentum continues; *Result Update*
28-Jan-26	Vodafone Idea	AGR relief, but still a long way to go; *Result Update*

Rating and Daily Volume Interpretation



Source: Bloomberg, Nuvama research

Rating Rationale & Distribution: Nuvama Research

Rating	Expected absolute returns over 12 months	Rating Distribution
Buy	15%	224
Hold	<15% and >-5%	65
Reduce	<-5%	31

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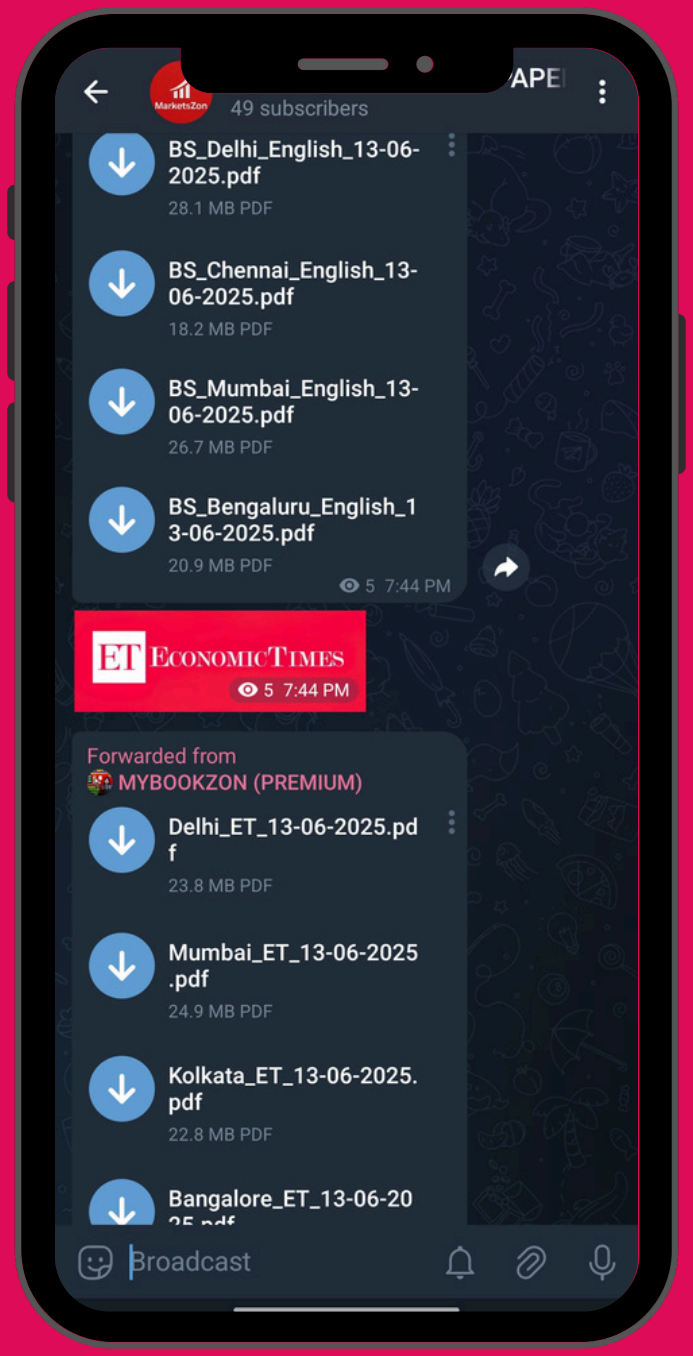

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